

**Light Speaker**

Transparent has made a portable speaker that mimics a warmly-lit lantern.
<https://digit.in/dec20-61>

**Sony Alpha 7C**

Sony's latest entry in the Alpha series features a full-frame sensor in a compact design.
<https://digit.in/dec20-62>

Philips TAPB603

3.1 Soundbar

A pleasant surprise



The Rs 30k to 40k price point seems to be the sweet spot for a good soundbar when it comes to performance and features. Here, we have with us yet another Dolby Atmos capable soundbar, the Philips 3.1 PB603 soundbar. Is it a worthy contender to the Sony, Yamaha and more bars in this price segment? Let's find out.

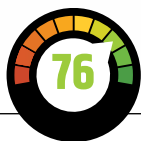
Build and design

A futuristic angular design is the first thing that will come to mind when you see the soundbar for the first time. It has a traditional rectangular form factor as we've seen on so many soundbars, but the soundbar looks like it's leaning forward when you look at it from the side. It also looks like it is dual-layered giving it a unique look. The front and top of the soundbar are covered by a mesh grille and the side has a silver colour. What we don't like is the button placement. The physical controls are on the right side of the soundbar. We would have preferred the controls on top of the soundbar making them easier to reach.

All the ports are conveniently located at the back of the soundbar facing outwards. We have the power port along with the optical, USB and Aux port on one side and a few centimetres away we have the three HDMI ports. We have one ARC port and the other two are pass-through ports.

Performance

Before we get into performance, know that even if you connect the soundbar



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to your TV via HDMI ARC, there are no on-screen controls (on the TV). Secondly, even though the soundbar supports Dolby Atmos, don't expect the sound to come from above or behind you.

Now, coming to the performance, holy smokes! As unassuming the subwoofer

looks, its performance is just the opposite. Watch a movie like Greyhound on Apple TV+ and this subwoofer will smack you with the right kind of rumble when the ships hit the sea or when the bombing attacks start. Same thing for movies on Netflix like The Old Guard or even Extraction. These are movies mastered in Dolby Atmos and even though the surround sound is absent from the soundbar, it has good channel separation. Even the dialogues on these movies are a lot clearer than what we've heard on the Yamaha YAS 209. The Philips 3.1 soundbar packs in 320W of sound output and while that's 80 less than the 400W found on the Sony HT-G700, it can get pretty loud and room-filling for the average-sized living room.

The soundbar has 3 presets – News, Movies and Music along with a surround on and surround off. For each situation, the representing preset works nicely. If you like watching documentaries that don't have much dramatic background music, then you can also consider the News preset as this one reduced the bass considerably.

Coming to music, the Music preset of the Philips 3.1 soundbar does fine. The vocals are punchy, instruments clear and the audio doesn't crackle at

high volumes. Whether you like listening to classical music, rock or even some pop, this soundbar does a good job. However, the bass in music on the Philips is slightly more overpowering than we'd like.

For gaming, we played Marvel Spider-Man, The Last of Us Part II, Ghost of Tsushima, and Doom. Channel separation works well in all the games, especially when playing Spider-Man. You can hear the city pass you when swinging with chatter from the street clearly audible. Once again, don't expect to hear the enemies from behind you but the overall gaming experience is immersive.

So, what's missing from the Philips 3.1 soundbar? Well, for one thing, we wish there was an app that could be used to control the soundbar.

REMOTE CONTROL

The bundled remote control with the is quite well built and better than the one you get with the YAS 209. It runs on a button cell rather than AAA batteries.

It has a traditional rectangular design but has a rubbery finish which adds to the grip. All the buttons are neatly laid out in two rows. On the remote control, you have the options for source, EQ, Dolby button to engage surround sound, buttons to control the treble and bass and dedicated playback controls along with volume controls.

VERDICT

What the Philips 3.1 soundbar has going for it is great sound output for movies, music and games. It has a simple and easy to use remote control. So, despite some competition, if you have a budget of 30K, then you can consider this soundbar.

—Sameer Mitha

SPECIFICATIONS

3.1 CH wireless subwoofer | Dolby Atmos | 2 HDMI In & HDMI out ARC | 320W | SPEAKER OUTPUT POWER: 200W | SUBWOOFER OUTPUT POWER: 120W | SPEAKER SYSTEM OUTPUT POWER: 320W | MAIN UNIT SPEAKER DRIVERS: L: full range (48x90mm) + tweeter; R: full range (48x90mm) + tweeter; C: full range (52mm) x 2

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